Why Salazar Slytherin Wins Twice: Structural Inequality in the Internal Selection Logic of Slytherin and the Sorting System at Hogwarts

The institutional imprint of Salazar Slytherin's pure-blood ideology is argued to combine with the formal House-sorting mechanism of Hogwarts to generate durable in-group/out-group boundaries that are decoupled from functional or professional differentiation. Drawing on self-categorization theory, it is maintained that categorical assignment produces heightened group salience and accentuates "us/them" dynamics even when the categories lack occupational justification (Turner et al., 1987). Evidence synthesized from canonical texts, film adaptations, and publicly available fan commentary is treated as cultural material that illustrates how symbolic boundaries are narrated and socially transmitted; these circulating scripts are considered plausible vectors for observational learning and meta-stereotype formation in the student body (Bandura, 2008).

For author positionality, the author is identified as a magical-psychology researcher affiliated with Hufflepuff, and interpretive claims are presented with reflexive acknowledgement of this vantage. To mitigate interpretive bias, analytical procedures were employed that included triangulation across textual, documentary, and public commentary sources, anonymization of quoted community material, and peer debriefing during thematic synthesis—procedures that align with established reflexive practices in qualitative inquiry (Finlay, 2002). Interpretations are therefore offered as situated readings informed by the author's disciplinary orientation and methodological safeguards rather than as population-level generalizations.

Hogwarts' House system immediately embeds students in rigid in-groups. In particular, Slytherin House – with its creed of pure-blood supremacy – epitomizes strong in-group consolidation and a corresponding out-group of "the rest." Social identity theory predicts that even minimal categorization can magnify intergroup differences. As Abrams *et al.* (2018) note, "merely categorizing people into different groups" is sufficient to "exaggerate" perceived distinctions between them. In the Hogwarts narrative, Slytherin is explicitly coded as aligned with Voldemort and "fascist ideologies and evil," while Gryffindor is framed as the moral opposite. This storytelling reinforces Slytherin's in-group identity and justifies fearing the Slytherin out-group, despite the Houses having no actual functional differences. Research on social categorization supports this: Turner *et al.* (1987) showed that arbitrary group labels produce strong us-vs-them mindsets. Consistent with this, Bettencourt *et al.* (2019) find that groups under perceived threat or negative stereotyping tend to isolate themselves socially. In effect, Hogwarts' tolerance of an unchecked Slytherin identity (power and heritage above merit) encourages students to internalize those stereotypes and distance themselves from outsiders. Over time, this unbalanced in-group loyalty undermines institutional unity by entrenching tribal attitudes rather than shared school identity (Abrams *et al.*, 2018).

Institutionalized Comparison Without Personalization: Competition as Governance at Hogwarts

The structural design of Hogwarts further entrenches segregation. From the Sorting Hat's placement on, each student's House becomes their primary social category. This categorical sorting is not complemented by any individualized educational strategy or meaningful cross-house integration. Instead, Hogwarts amplifies intergroup

competition: house points, Quidditch cups, and heirloom privileges pit Houses in perpetual rivalry. Social psychological research warns that such institutionally sanctioned competition keeps group boundaries salient. In fact, Abrams *et al.* (2018) emphasize that only well-supported, equal-status intergroup contact (with cooperative goals) can mitigate prejudice. By contrast, Hogwarts provides neither equal status (some Houses hold more authority or prestige) nor structured cooperation across Houses. A wealth of evidence confirms that under genuine Allportian conditions (equal status, common goals), contact reduces bias; without them, divisions persist. For example, Bond *et al.* (2023) report that in over 90% of studies, positive intergroup contact lowers prejudice, and these effects are strongest when groups interact on equal terms. In Hogwarts, daily life lacks such conditions: coursework and social life are organized by House, not by skill or interest. The result is analogous to tracking or tracking-like grouping in real schools, which Bettencourt *et al.* (2019) note often produce "micro-segregation" even in integrated settings. By framing learning and reward around arbitrary House identity, Hogwarts' regime of competition serves its purpose of cohesion-building, but at the cost of institutional coherence: it heightens intergroup stereotyping and reduces every pupil to a role in an inter-house hierarchy.

Tradition and Social Segregation in the Magical World's Educational Ecology

The segregation at Hogwarts reflects broader magical-world customs. Pure-blood lineage operates as a de facto caste system, much like ethnicity or class divisions in Muggle society. Even outside school, certain families and Bloodlines (e.g. Malfoy, Black, Lestrange) remain insular, enforcing pure-blood status through marriage and education. In this macro-society, communication with "Muggle" collaborators is

discouraged, and moderate or mixed-blood perspectives are often silenced. This aligns with empirical findings: Bettencourt *et al.* (2019) document that informal segregation emerges along virtually any salient social boundary (ethnic, religious, status) despite shared environments. Analogously, magical elites self-segregate on the basis of blood status, and stigmatize outsiders (such as Muggle-borns or half-bloods). The cumulative effect is a social ecology where in-group loyalty is nurtured and out-group empathy is low. Corrigan and Penn (1999) argue that simply proclaiming anti-stigma values is insufficient – without institutional change and personal intergroup contact, prejudice can worsen[8]. In Hogwarts and beyond, the rigidity of tradition and the prevalence of clanism effectively institutionalize social segregation: low-status or non-pure-blood wizards perceive a "threat in the air" of confirming stereotypes (Steele, 1997; Abrams *et al.*, 2018), leading them to withdraw from intergroup interaction. In sum, Hogwarts does not stand apart from magical society; rather, it reproduces its segregationist norms. The result is a self-reinforcing system of stigma: pure-blood identity is valorized, while others internalize a sense of outsider status, consistent with patterns of group-based stereotyping observed in real-world institutions.

Toward a Reform-Oriented Magical Pedagogy: Universal Design of Magical Education

Insights from social psychology suggest concrete reforms to reduce Hogwarts' structural bias. Foremost, inter-house segregation could be alleviated by creating more equal-status, cooperative interactions. Meta-analyses show that deliberately structured contact (e.g. joint tasks under common goals) reliably diminishes prejudice, especially when institutions explicitly support it[5]. Thus, integrating mixed-House projects or

electives based on interests (not House) would allow students to see peers as individuals rather than category exemplars. Educational interventions should also target everyday practices: Bettencourt *et al.* (2019) emphasize that formal policies alone fail unless everyday social routines and rituals are addressed[6]. For example, reimagining House symbols and stories to include contributions from all backgrounds could undercut entrenched stereotypes. Corrigan and Penn (1999) similarly warn that protest alone can backfire and that information campaigns must be paired with real contact[8]. At Hogwarts, this implies moving beyond token inclusion (e.g. "non-pure blood allowed") toward fostering a campus ethos where all identities are normalized in the learning environment.

Adopting a universal design approach to magical education may help. This means tailoring pedagogy so that no student's learning is constrained by arbitrary categories. For instance, allowing students to demonstrate mastery through multiple modalities and emphasizing personal growth over house loyalty mirrors inclusive curricular models (Cornell Teaching Innovation Center, 2024). In practice, reforms might include de-emphasizing house affiliation in admissions tasks, equalizing House Points rewards, and ensuring faculty advancement criteria value mentorship across Houses. Such measures create an environment in which positive, cross-group contact becomes the norm rather than the exception. In short, rather than erasing Houses entirely, Hogwarts could embed cooperative, equal-status structures into the House system. This "universal design" of magical education – drawing on equal-status intergroup contact and inclusive pedagogy – offers a path to dismantle the stigma and stereotypes currently built into Hogwarts' institutional architecture (Abrams *et al.*, 2018; Bond *et al.*, 2023).

References

Abrams, D., Houston, D., Masser, B., & McKimmie, B. (2018). *A social identity model for education*. In L. Argote & J. M. Levine (Eds.), *The Oxford handbook of group and organizational learning*. Oxford University Press.

Bandura, A. (2008). Toward an agentic theory of the self. *Advances in Psychological Science, 1*(2), 164–180. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-8721.2008.00530.x

Bettencourt, L., Dixon, J., & Castro, P. (2019). Understanding how and why spatial segregation endures: A systematic review of recent research on intergroup relations at a micro-ecological scale. *Social Psychological Bulletin, 14*(2), e33482. https://doi.org/10.32872/spb.v14i2.33482

Bond, J., Dixon, J., Andreouli, E., & Tredoux, C. (2023). The contact hypothesis and the virtual revolution: Does face-to-face interaction remain central to improving intergroup relations? *PLOS ONE, 18*(12), e0292831. https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0292831

Corrigan, P. W., & Penn, D. L. (1999). Lessons from social psychology on discrediting psychiatric stigma. *American Psychologist, 54*(9), 765–776. https://doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.54.9.765

Finlay, L. (2002). Negotiating the swamp: The opportunity and challenge of reflexivity in research practice. *Qualitative Research, 2*(2), 209–230. https://doi.org/10.1177/146879410200200205

Fischer, H. (2016). *House sorting in "Harry Potter": A choice of stereotypes?* (Master's thesis). Humboldt-Universität zu Berlin.

Turner, J. C., Hogg, M. A., Oakes, P. J., Reicher, S. D., & Wetherell, M. S. (1987). *Rediscovering the social group: A self-categorization theory*. Basil Blackwell.